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EDUCATION AND TRAINING DEPARTMENT

QUALIFICATION: PROFESSIONAL TECHNICAL TRAINER LEVEL 6

UNIT OF COMPETENCY: DEVELOP CBET CURRICULUM

UNIT CODE: ED/B/7102

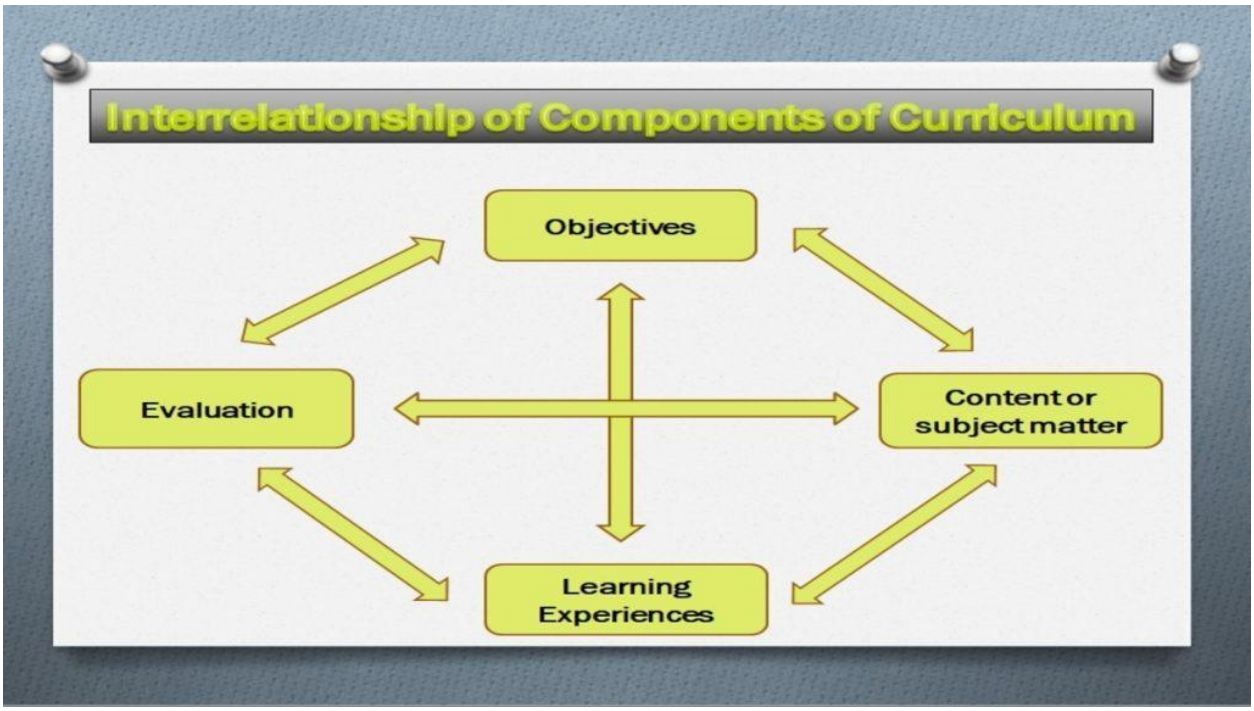
Elements of a Curriculum

These are the components or main parts of the curriculum.

According to Tyler (1949), it is essential as a part of comprehensive theory of organization to show what elements of curriculum will serve satisfactorily as organizing elements.

The appropriate coordination of elements of curriculum would guarantee the success of a curriculum. There is no consensus among the experts on elements of curriculum, but the most four common points of view concerning this issue are:

1. Objectives
2. Content or subject matter
3. Methods or learning experiences
4. Evaluation.



These four basic elements of curriculum are essential and interrelated to each other:

1. Aims, goals, and objectives can be simplified as “what is the purpose of the education and training process”.
2. Subject matter/content is “what subject matter is to be delivered to attain the aim/goal/objective”.
3. Learning experiences is “what instructional strategies, resources and activities will be employed to deliver the subject matter/content.
4. Curriculum evaluation is “what methods and instruments will be used to assess the results of the curriculum”

Let us look at each of the elements:

1. CURRICULUM OBJECTIVES

Also called educational objectives. They are descriptions of the ends being sought in educating learners in the society. “*What are the general objective (or ends sought) for schools to be established and for what purpose are students being taught in the schools*”. Curriculum objectives are expressed in three categories:

a) Aims of Education

Aims are general and broad statements of intent that provide direction or intent to educational action.

Aims are guides for the educational process as expressed by policy makers, educationists, politicians. Educational aims guide the education system in the process of planning education content. Aims are usually written in amorphous terms using words like: learn, know, understand, appreciate, and these are not directly measurable.

b) Goals of Education

Goals are broad statements of educational intention which are specified for each level of schooling from pre-primary education to higher education levels. They are time-bound and are stated as expected end-result of schooling at each level of Kenyan education. They may be in either amorphous language or in more specific behavioral terms.

c) Instructional Objectives

Instructional objectives describe an intended behavioral change that a learner is expected to exhibit (knowledge, skills, techniques or attitudes acquired) after undergoing a learning experience. An instructional objective is a statement that will describe what the learner will be able to do after completing the instruction within a specified time. Instructional objectives are descriptions of an outcome of action. It is normally expressed in behavioral terms using action verbs.

FUNCTIONS OF CURRICULUM OBJECTIVES

i. Define the direction of educational development
ii. Determine the number of levels for the program
iii. Inform students of the standards and expectations of the course
iv. Serve as an implicit contract between instructor and students, setting up a basis for accountability.
v. Drive the curriculum planning
vi. Guide decisions about selection of content, learning experiences and learning strategies
vii. Serve as a guide in evaluating instructional progress
viii. Reflect the needs and aspirations of society

SOURCES OF CURRICULUM OBJECTIVES

Needs assessment is a prerequisite for selecting objectives. An assessment of needs therefore is an evaluation of what is required by society in educating the learners. In order to conduct good needs

assessment, a validated method of collecting data on opinions of various segment of the society are required. Such information or data are good sources of curriculum objectives.

1) Needs of society

The needs of every nation differs from one another, similarly, the needs of a nation at any point in history differs from another period in her history. The needs of society keep changing. These needs are usually stated as ideologies, value system or a national philosophy. In fact no policy on education-can be formulated without first identifying the overall philosophy and goal of the nation.

- Changing life in the society- economic, technological, political, religious etc
- Problems and needs of the society
- Helps community utilize its resources
- Changing the society for the better – poverty, corruption, inflation, leadership wrangles
- Social and cultural needs of the society

It is because of these important needs in every society that has prompted some experts to advocate that curriculum should be society-oriented.

2) Students' Needs and Interests

A study of the learners would seek to identify the needed changes in behavior patterns that an educational institution would seek to attain in its study. The learner is the recipient of the curriculum therefore their interests and needs should be known to be able to catch their attention. A need is the gap or difference between the present condition of the learner and the desirable acceptable norm of the society.

- Learners' ability both physical and mental should be reviewed.
- Consider the special needs of exceptional children.
- Learners' needs should be perceived from both the individuality and societal needs

Learners can make very useful contributions in formulating curriculum objectives, in the following ways:

(a) Suggesting what is to be taught in line with their needs, interests, maturation and background

(b) Suggesting what materials will best enhance effective learning

3) Input from Academic Specialist:

Subject specialists are also very crucial in formulating curriculum objectives because they are the ones to implement all school programmes. Subject specialists are teachers whose roles are vital because they interact with learners and they know their needs better than other personnel. Teachers' responsibilities extend beyond the classroom because they exert tremendous influence over the learners. They also act as *in loco parent* is for students. They know students well and can give advice or suggestions on various ways to adequately educate the learners. Teachers are expected to play the following roles in curriculum planning;

- Assist in formulating curriculum objectives and policy;
- Selection and determination of learning activities that will be necessary for the achievement of the stated objectives;
- Use their knowledge of complex nature of child psychology and children development in planning learning activities;
- Maintain high standard of conduct and discipline as an effort towards meeting the goals of education;
- Carry out the evaluation of student performance which are useful in formulating future curriculum objectives.

Advantages of using academic specialists

- All text books written in schools are written by subject specialists so their views are those contained in the books and so makes learning easier
- Syllabuses produced by KNEC and KIE is the work of the subject specialists
- Course and subject panels at KIE are composed of people who are experienced and expertise in their subject
- Ensure organization of knowledge is relevant and worthwhile
- Ensure knowledge introduced is dynamic and methods of learning are relevant

4) Community Sources of Educational Objectives:

A community is a group of people living together in a given geographical area, and sharing common culture and a way of life, and acting collectively towards achieving a common goal. It is expedient that a school teaches the norms and values of the community where it is situated. In formulating curriculum objectives, community advisory groups might be set to present proposal based on the peculiar problems and experiences of community members. These are then ploughed into the curriculum objectives being

specified especially curriculum planning at the community level. There are community resources available in educating a child. Such resources include input form parent, input from certain vocational groups, and suing field trips as important aids to learning. Certainly community input in formulating educational objectives cannot be overemphasized in fulfilling these general national objectives of education at community level.

5) **Psychodynamic factors**

Before a child can learn appropriately, he must adequately develop physically and mentally. The complex nature of child development has implication for curriculum planning even from the selection of objectives. Educational Psychologists have made significant contributions through their studies, into the factors which influence learning. Modern psychology has broadened and modified perspectives on how children learn. For example, the principle of biological inheritance and Intelligent Quotients (IQ) can set a limit to how much a child can learn. In such a case, there will be need to cater for individual differences in ability to learn when developing curriculum.

Another issue is the issue of readiness, maturation and learning. Here the age of the learner has considerable influence on what or how much he can learn. Until a child's cognitive development reaches a certain point which corresponds with certain ages, the child may not be able to learn certain materials. Thus, before selecting curriculum objectives, all these factors must be taken into consideration

SCREENS OF CURRICULUM OBJECTIVES

To screen means to examine or to test the curriculum objectives. Curriculum objectives are screened to find out the following:

- If they are relevant
- If they are adequate
- If they are valid
- If they are within the scope
- If they are appropriate/suitable to meet the needs of the learners and society

In order to establish the relevance, adequacy, validity, scope and suitability of a curriculum, it is important that the curriculum is filtered through the screens outlined below:

Types of screens

Philosophical Screens:

These constitute the values and beliefs held by a particular nation. They guide the behavior of the citizens of a given country. The philosophical orientation that the education system promotes forms an integral part of the culture of the nation. The philosophical statements usually are expressed in the manifesto of the governing political party of the day. For example in Kenya during the KANU era, the philosophical values expressed were peace, love and unity.

Psychological Screens

Psychologists are concerned with understanding patterns of human behavior in order to describe, control and predict human behavior. They also look for determinants of behavior in hereditary as well as environmental influences. Insights gained in psychology have a bearing when developing a curriculum. Psychological screen takes account of classroom behavior of learners. The following issues should be addressed when screening the appropriateness and scope of curriculum objectives:

- Capabilities of the learner
- Maturational level of the learners
- Students rate of learning
- How students learn
- Individual aspects

Sociological Screens

An obligation of the school is building a curriculum under which the individuals can acquire values and competence for a life in the society. Sociological screen are determined by the culture of a society, which indicated norms, values and complete requirements that are cherished by the society. In approaching curriculum planning analyzing and drawing from the society will indicate:

- The kind the knowledge, skills and competence that youth in society will need so that they can cope with tasks and roles in that society
- The problems prevalent in society for which education should provide an answer e.g. technological, economical, poverty, corruption, unemployment, drugs etc

In sociological screens the curriculum designer is actually dealing with cultural values, societal needs and learners' background (family and religious influences).

2. LEARNING EXPERIENCES

Objectives have been defined as changes in behavior that we expect in the learners after going through an educational program. To be able to achieve these objectives learners have to undergo certain experiences. Essentially learning takes place through the experiences, which the leaner has, that is through the reactions he makes with the environment in which he is placed (Tyler, 1949).

According to Tyler, a learning experience is the interaction between the learners and the conditions in the learning environment to which they react. Learning experiences include the learning opportunities provided to the learners. Examples of learning experiences/opportunities include:

- ✓ The teacher
- ✓ Resource persons
- ✓ Fellow learners
- ✓ Resource materials
- ✓ Teaching methods
- ✓ Learning activities that enable the learners to interact with this assorted environment of the school setting

Organization of Learning Experiences

Once learning experiences and opportunities have been selected, they have to be organized so that the desired learning can take place. Usually, the curriculum is organized according to subjects. The learning experiences within a subject are organized at three levels:

- The units – covers several topics related to a theme
- The topic- which may cover several lessons to last several days
- The lesson- planned for several days to cover a given topic

3. CONTENT

Curriculum objectives determine the content that will be taught. Content comprises the subjects and topics to be covered. The curriculum content should strive to achieve the national aims and goals of education as well as the instructional objectives as shown in any curriculum.

Criteria for selection of content and learning experiences

i. **Conformity with objectives:** experiences selected must be thoroughly weighed against the school curricula objectives to ensure it gives the students an opportunity to practice the kind of behavior implied by the objectives

ii. **Validity:** whatever experiences be it content, learning activities, or materials must be consistent with development in the subject or knowledge area. To avoid giving obsolete or out of date instruction teachers need to constantly go for retraining and self education to keep abreast of changes in their disciplines

iii. **Significance:** learning experiences must be meaningful in that it contributes to the process of learning. This relates to breadth and depth of the curriculum. Teachers should avoid covering too much concepts, which are in conflict with the objectives of the topic. This can lead to confusion and students not making sense of the content and many activities.

iv. **Learner ability:** learning experiences must be adjusted to the abilities of the learners and individual differences. Students also readily experience what is related to their past experiences. Learning experiences also depends on the circumstances prevailing in their schools, classrooms and society at large. Some may favor while other may not favor experiences selected for learning.

v. **Interests:** students are likely to interact with situations that are inviting or stimulating. To ignore their interest is to lose their motivation hence affecting the rate at which learning takes place.

vi. **Satisfaction:** learning experiences must be such that learners derive satisfaction from carrying out the kind of behavior implied by the objectives

vii. **Relevance:** learners must see his experiences as being related to life outside the school to solve his problems or problems of the society in real life.

viii. **Consistency with social reality:** learning experiences may address the objectives but should not contradict actual situation at home or in society

ix. **Economy:** select learning objectives that are likely to bring about a number of learning outcomes. These permit economy in the use of time.

x. **Reinforcement:** By nature, certain experiences cannot be achieved through a single experience. Selection of learning experiences that reinforce previous or other experiences to achieve objectives can be very useful.

Principles of organization of content and learning experiences

Scope: scope describes what is covered or learned. Scope points to breadth and depth of content. Breadth is the amount of detail to include in our teaching while depth is the amount of emphasis this detail should receive. Scope should help students acquire the desired knowledge, skills and attitudes for their level.

Sequence: is vertical development from one level to another. It refers to building of new knowledge while drawing from that, which was earlier acquired as it increases in depth and breadth. Some curriculum specialists have tried to apply the principles of simple to complex or familiar to unfamiliar in trying to overcome the sequencing problem.

Continuity: refers to the many occasions an individual will experience content at different levels of an educational program. It helps the learner through development of skills because important objectives and content are continued and repeated to enable students to acquire high levels of retention level in the area.

Integration: it emphasizes horizontal relationships between different curricula areas in an attempt to interrelate content or learning experiences in order to enable students perceive unity of knowledge. The cal for integration is to make learning more effective when content from one field is linked meaningfully to content from another field to get a unified view of students' outlook, skills and attitudes.

Balance: a balances program ensures that each educational objective is adequately achieved. A balanced curriculum should develop all major areas concerned with human competence in meeting both the individual and society problems.

4. Curriculum Evaluation

Evaluation is the process of establishing the extent to which the objectives of a programme are being or have been achieved and in which areas it needs improvement.

It is an appraisal of the worth of an educational undertaking – from the results, a decision can be made to accept, improve or reject the educational program.

Evaluation is a process of collection and provision of data for the sake of facilitating decision making at various stages of curriculum development (Shiundu&Omulando, 1992, p. 185). Curriculum evaluation refers to the process of collecting data in a systematic manner for the purpose of assessing quality, effectiveness and worth of a programme.

Some of the areas that are evaluated

- Objectives
- Scope of the content
- Quality of personnel
- Relative importance of various school subjects
- Equipment's and instructional materials

Purposes of the Evaluation

a) **Individual Students**

- To discover what the students have learnt (knowledge, skills, attitudes and adjustment etc)
- To discover where the learner needs help, the nature of the help, his/her areas of strength.
- Data necessary to guide each learner's all round growth and development.

b) **Classroom Purposes**

Provides data that enables the teacher to determine the effectiveness of teaching i.e.

- Which of the objectives have been achieved?
- Is the content relevant and adequate?
- Are the methods and activities relevant and practicable?
- Is re-teaching necessary

c) **Curriculum Materials**

- Are they relevant, usable, appropriate and affordable?

d) **Schools - Wide Purposes**

- Asses the overall effectiveness of the institutional programme.
- Reveal learning areas needing more attention throughout the school.
- Assist the school administration and staff in planning for institutional improvement.

e) Curriculum Developers

- To provide supportive feedback to facilitate effective decision making in the curriculum development process
- Provide information required for re-examination, revision and improvement of the curriculum project
- Serves as a guide in review of existing goals of education and formulation of new ones
- Provides information for correction during piloting
- Ensures program objectives are being achieved during implementation

f) Community

- What are the attitudes and inputs of the community to the curriculum and to the curriculum development process?

Essentially, evaluation ensures that strengths and weaknesses are detected at an early stage thus saving time, resources and frustration and increase the chances of success of a programme.

Types of Evaluation

a) **Pre-assessment / Reflective evaluation/ Diagnostic assessment**

Is conducted at the inception of a curriculum project.

In a classroom environment it is the process that helps to determine whether the students possess the prerequisite knowledge and skills to enable them proceed with new material. This is useful at the beginning of a new course or for a new teacher posted in a class he/she has not handled before.

b) **Formative Evaluation**

Formation evaluation is that which takes place during the implementation of a curriculum project or programme. It therefore guides and promotes the development of the programme, by providing data for its

improvement. Note: Formative evaluation should take place at all stages of curriculum development and implementation

c) **Summative Evaluation**

Refers to evaluation carried out at the end of a programme. It facilitates major decisions about whether to continue with the programme as it is; expand it, modify it or stop it all together depending on the extent of success or failure of the programme.

d) **Impact evaluation**

Is an aspect of summative evaluation; it establishes the impact of the programme on the beneficiaries or recipients of the programme, and the community in general.

Criteria for Curriculum Evaluation

Consistency with objectives: Curriculum evaluation should assess and measure the attainment of the objectives of the curriculum. The various domains need to be kept in mind i.e. cognitive, affective and psychomotor. Each level of learning objectives as per each taxonomy should be examined

Comprehensiveness: To test for comprehensiveness the areas to be covered include:

- All the objectives of the curriculum
- The broad administrative and general aspects of the education systems to find out how relevant the programme is.
- The instructional methods and materials to establish those that are satisfactory and those which are not;
- The individual learners to identify their needs and to help one plan better for the learning process.
- The teachers to find out how well they are performing

Validity: This criterion answers the question “Do the evaluation instruments used e.g. examinations and tests measure the function they are intended to measure?”

Reliability: Reliable instruments should give same results when administered at different times.

Continuity: Evaluation should be a continuous process; an integral part of the curriculum development process and classroom instruction. Hence, provide continuous feedback on weaknesses and strengths; for remedial action to be taken

Relevance: This indicates the value of the intervention or programme in relation to other stakeholders needs, national priorities, international partners' policies, including the millennium development goals, national development plans etc

Efficiency: Answers the question; "Does the programme use the resources in the most economical manner to achieve its goals.

Effectiveness: Is the activity achieving satisfactory results in relation to stated objectives?

Impact: What are the results of the intervention, intended and unintended; positive and negative – including social, economic, environmental effects on individuals, institutions and communities?

Sustainability: This addresses the issue: "Are the activities and their impact likely to continue when external support is withdrawn, and will it be more widely replicated and adopted." For example if a country institutes "Free Primary Education" as is currently the case in Kenya and many other African countries, with heavy donor support, is this likely to continue in the future.

Methods of evaluation

- Questionnaires
- Interviews
- Tests
- Observation
- Documentary analysis
- Focused group discussions

The Role of Teachers in Curriculum Evaluation

- Teachers provide data on the progress of students and of materials.
- Teachers are best placed to judge the quality of materials, the depth to which the topics have been or should be dealt with and the sequencing of the topics.

- Teachers are involved in observing and documenting their observations, constructing appropriate tests and examinations, and reporting their findings in a systematic manner.
- Teachers are required to document their experiences and those of the learners. These
- Experiences are reported in the subject panels during curriculum development process

Curriculum Development Models

1. **Tyler's Model of Curriculum Development**

Developed by Ralph Tyler in the 1940's' it is the quintessential prototype of curriculum development in the scientific approach. One could almost dare to say that every certified teacher has developed curricula either directly or indirectly using this model or one of the many variations.

Tyler did not intend for his contribution to curriculum to be a lockstep model for development. Originally, he wrote down his ideas in a book Basic Principles of Curriculum and Instruction for his students to give them an idea about principles to follow in developing a curriculum.

The brilliance of Tyler's model is that it was one of the first models and it still is a highly simple model consisting of four steps.

1. Determine the school's purposes (aka objectives)
2. Identify educational experiences related to purpose
3. Organize the experiences
4. Evaluate the purposes

Basic Principles of Curriculum and Instruction according to Tyler

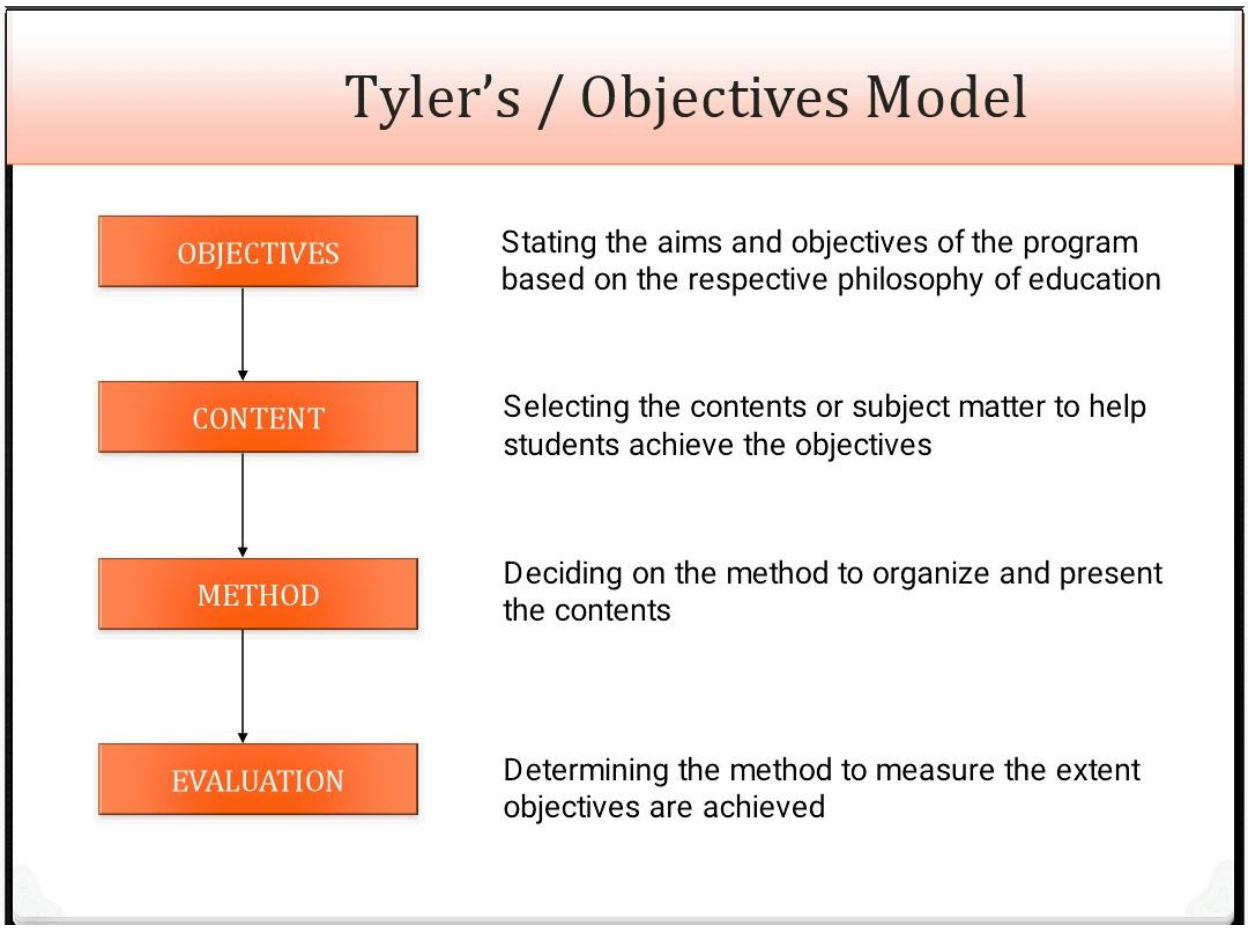
Step one: is **determining the objectives of the school or class**. In other words, what do the students need to do in order to be successful? Each subject has natural objectives that are indicators of mastery. All objectives need to be consistent with the philosophy of the school and this is often neglected in curriculum development. For example, a school that is developing an English curriculum may create an objective that students will write essays. This would be one of many objectives within the curriculum.

Step two: is **developing learning experiences** that help the students to achieve step one. For example, if students need to meet the objective of writing an essay. The learning experience might be a demonstration by the teacher of writing an essay. The students then might practice writing essays. The experience (essay demonstration and writing) is consistent with the objective (Student will write an essay).

Step three: is **organizing the experiences**. Should the teacher demonstrate first or should the students learn by writing immediately? Either way could work and preference

is determined by the philosophy of the teacher and the needs of the students. The point is that the teacher needs to determine a logical order of experiences for the students.

Step four: is **evaluation of the objectives**. Now the teacher assesses the students' ability to write an essay. There are many ways to do this. For example, the teacher could have the students write an essay without assistance. If they can do this, it is evidence that the students have achieved the objective of the lesson. There are variations on this model. However, the Tyler model is still considered to be the strongest model for curriculum development.



2. Wheeler's Model of Curriculum Development

The Wheeler model of curriculum development is a cyclical, responsive approach that views curriculum as a continuous process of planning, implementation, and evaluation. It emphasizes a thorough situational analysis to understand the context and needs of learners and incorporates evaluation of feedback to improve the curriculum.

Unlike some linear models, Wheeler's model prioritizes selecting learning experiences before content, viewing this as crucial for shaping student engagement and learning

Stage 1: Formulation of Educational Aims, Goals and Objectives: The first stage in wheeler's model is the formulation of educational aims, goals and objectives. It is concerned with the role education should play in the lives of the individuals and the society at large.

Stage 2: Selection of Learning Experiences: The second stage is selection of learning experiences. Learning experiences refer to the activities, topics or subject matter as well as other materials that are presented to the learners. It is however important to state that only those learning experiences that promote intended learning outcomes should be selected.

Stage 3: Selection and Integration of Content: The third stage is concerned with the selection and integration of contents. This entails the scope and detailed description of the learning experiences. This is important so that teachers will not teach the learners out of content.

Stage 4: Organization of Selected Learning Experiences: This stage has to do with how selected learning experiences are being organized for presentation in order to meet the learner's needs.

Appropriate instructional materials and techniques are also put into consideration so as to achieve stated objectives.

Stage 5: Evaluation: Evaluation is the last stage in Wheeler's curriculum model. It focuses on how much of set objectives have been achieved.

Wheeler's model is presented as follows:

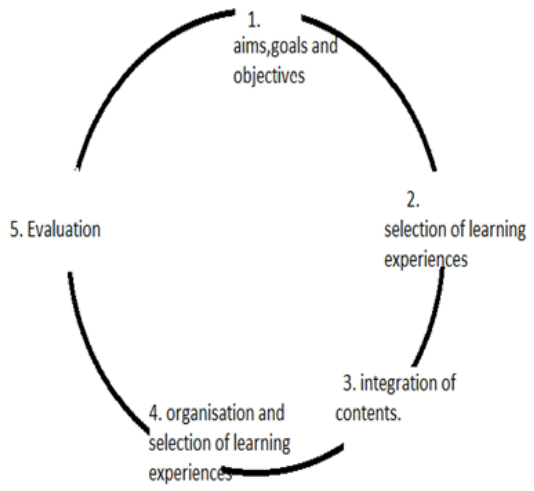


Figure 1: Wheeler's Model of Curriculum Planning

3. KICD Curriculum Development Model

Key Stages of the KICD Curriculum Development Model:

1. **Needs Assessment:**

KICD conducts research to identify the specific needs and expectations of the country regarding education, including desired competencies, learning areas, and pedagogical approaches.

2. **Conceptualization and Policy Formulation:**

Based on the needs assessment, KICD develops a conceptual framework and policy guidelines for the new curriculum.

3. **Curriculum Design:**

KICD designs the curriculum framework, including subject areas, learning outcomes, and assessment methods.

4. **Syllabus Development and Approval:**

Specific syllabuses for each subject and grade level are developed and approved by KICD.

5. **Curriculum Support Material Development:**

KICD develops and approves textbooks, teacher guides, and other resources to support curriculum implementation.

6. **Preparation of Curriculum Implementers:**

KICD trains teachers and other stakeholders on how to implement the new curriculum effectively.

7. **Piloting:**

The curriculum is tested in a limited number of schools before national implementation.

8. **National Implementation:**

The curriculum is rolled out to all schools across the country.

9. **Monitoring and Evaluation:**

KICD monitors the implementation of the curriculum and conducts evaluations to assess its effectiveness and make necessary adjustments.

4. DACUM Curriculum Development Model

The competence-based approach in curriculum design and subsequent competence-based curricula (CBC) focuses on competences required and relevant in the world of work and emphasizes skills related to *doing* rather than *knowing* (Njeng'ere & Lili, 2017). A competent student knows how and why things are done and what to do if things go wrong. They can perform a job properly and safely and can adapt to different situations. Due to the benefits of CBC, many educational institutions around the world are reviewing their curricula to be competence-based.

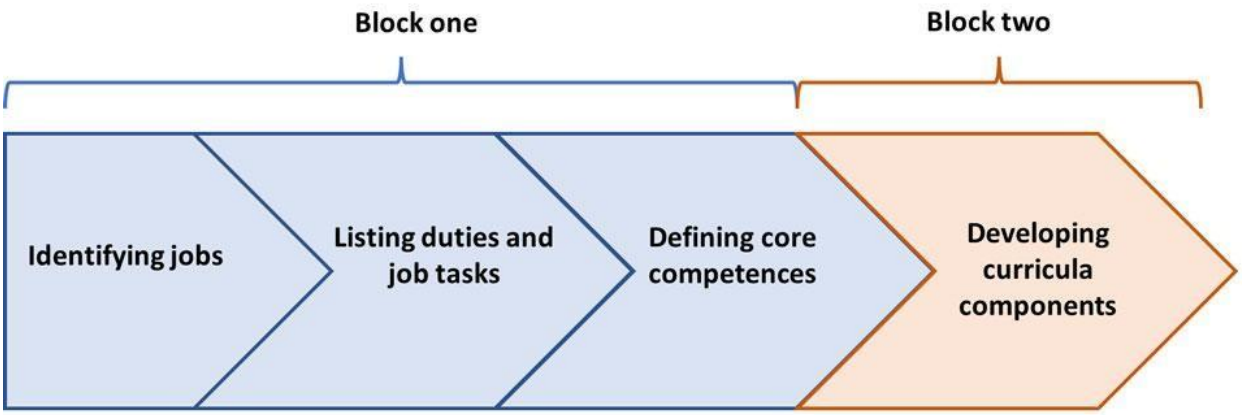
One concrete method of guiding curricula development and creating CBC is the DACUM method, an abbreviation for "*Develop A Curriculum*" (Norton, 1997, p. 1). The method, usually conducted as a few-day workshop, has been widely and successfully used to analyze the current and future professions and the skills and competences needed to perform in them (Norton, 1997, p. 2).

The DACUM process is a structured method for analyzing jobs and creating curricula by identifying the essential tasks, skills, and knowledge required for a specific occupation. It's a systematic approach that focuses on expert knowledge and the practical requirements of the job to inform curriculum development.

Development of a competence-based curriculum utilizing the DACUM method is composed of two blocks or working parts:

(1) Defining the core competences that will guide the development of the curriculum and (2) Building the competence-based curricula.

The first block is the core part of the process. To build a competence-based curriculum, one must know what competences to develop.



1. Identify Subject Matter Experts:

Gather a group of experienced practitioners in the field.

2. Facilitate a DACUM Workshop:

Guide the experts through a structured discussion to identify the key tasks, skills, knowledge, and attitudes required for the occupation.

3. Develop a DACUM Chart:

Create a visual representation of the job analysis, often using a flow chart or diagram, to map out the tasks, skills, and knowledge.

4. Refine and Iterate:

Review and refine the DACUM chart based on feedback from the experts and other stakeholders.

5. Develop the Curriculum:

Use the finalized DACUM chart as the foundation for designing the curriculum, including course objectives, content, learning activities, and assessment methods.

Curriculum Designs

Curriculum design involves the creation of an organizational plan for education professionals to use in their class. Teachers can use curriculum design to arrange their courses, create a schedule and design lesson plans.

In their curriculum design, teachers plan activities, coursework and educational assessments to help students achieve academic success.

Teachers may also design curriculum according to their school's specific guidelines and teaching standards. Schools may choose to standardize their curriculum design, which involves creating one curriculum design for all teachers within a school system to follow. For example, school administration may provide teachers with a curriculum design they must follow throughout the school year, which provides details on specific activities, due dates and coursework that teachers provide to students.

Types of Curriculum Designs

As a teacher, you can choose which type of curriculum design to use based on the size of your class and your student's educational needs. Schools may combine subject-centered curriculum with student-centered curriculum to create a design that covers the proper subjects and works with a variety of student.

1. Subject Centered Design

Subject-centered design involves giving students key facts and pieces of information associated with a particular discipline.

Teachers use subject-centered curriculum design when creating curriculum about a specific subject material or educational topic.

This type of curriculum design focuses on the educational material, rather than a specific learning style. For example, a teacher may make a curriculum design that focuses only on math concepts, using generalized activities that cater to a variety of learning styles.

It is common for teachers to use subject-centered design for larger classes since it may be more challenging to make student-centered curriculum involve each student in their class. While it's easier for schools to use subject-centered curriculum, it may be more challenging to use this curriculum design to cater to each student's specific needs.

2. Learner Centered Curriculum Design

Learner-centered design prioritizes students’ own interests and goals in the learning process.

This is a student-centered design that involves creating a curriculum according to the needs of the student.

A teacher may individualize a curriculum plan for each student, or they can create a curriculum design that involves the entire class. For example, a teacher may create a curriculum design for a student that finds it challenging to pay attention for a long period by including several small activities that don't require extensive amounts of attention. If their entire class prefers doing group work, then they may include activities in their curriculum design that involve working in small and large groups.

Often, learner-centered curriculum design involves allowing students to choose their assignments, activities and lessons according to their preferred learning style. By doing this, teachers may motivate students to take control of their education.

Teachers might find this type of curriculum design to be more challenging to complete since it requires more detailed instructions that are specific to each type of learning style. This design may be useful for teachers who have smaller classes, or for schools that have fewer students, as it may be easier for them to focus on each student's individual needs.

3. Problem Centered Curriculum Design

This is another form of student-centered design that focuses on a student's specific educational challenges.

This design centers around specific issues or problems, encouraging students to find solutions through inquiry and investigation.

Teachers can use problem-centered design after identifying areas of improvement for a student's learning. For example, if a teacher notices a student struggling to understand a specific concept, they can use this curriculum design to help the student better understand the information.

Teachers may also create problem-centered curriculum designs for common education challenges. So, if a teacher knows that students often have trouble with a specific subject, topic or process, they may use this design.

Problem-centered curriculum design refers to using activities to hone the skills that students will need post-graduation. Students continue to learn key skills and knowledge associated with their area of study, but lessons are designed around application and relevance.

4. Core Curriculum

The core curriculum provides students with “common learning” or general education that is considered necessary for all. Thus, the core curriculum constitutes the segment of the curriculum that teaches concepts, skills, and attitudes needed by all individuals to function effectively within the society or within a specific discipline/occupation.